However, perhaps the Persian government was not in such a predicament as the Foreign Office believed. In late November 1921, Moscow addressed two letters to the Persian government, complaining that the Soviet–Persian Treaty had still not been ratified by the Medjliss.[66] The reply from Persia was that the delay was due to 'difficulties in certain clauses'.[67] As Reginald Bridgeman of the British Legation in Tehran noted in his telegram to the Foreign Office, 'it looks as if fate of Anglo-Persian agreement may overtake Russo-Persian [one]'.[68] Perhaps, then, it was the Persian government which had played Soviet Russia off against Britain, and was now having the last laugh.

Quid Pro Quo

One place in which the combined forces of Bolshevism, Islamism and nationalism can be clearly seen in 1921 is Afghanistan. In this year India was to conclude an official treaty with its neighbour, a project made particularly difficult as the Indian government found itself negotiating with both Kabul and London at the same time, as well as trying to outmanoeuvre Moscow as it looked to secure its own treaty with the emir. Indeed, it is through examining the Afghan debates of 1921 that some of the fundamental differences between London and Delhi can be seen. In essence, the divergence lay in what each government believed to be the best way of securing the future of the empire. For the Indian government, having a friendly and stable ally in Kabul was essential for two main reasons. First, the viceroy and his council were adamant throughout this period that a treaty of friendship with Afghanistan would be important to the stability of India, not only in that it would help quell the tribal unrest on its borders, but because it would remove some of the impetus of the pan-Islamic movement. Secondly, it was believed that by such a treaty, Britain would be able to counter any Soviet presence within Afghanistan and prevent its neighbour from becoming a conduit for the dissemination of Bolshevik propaganda and agents into India. Crucially, the Indian government believed these points to be intertwined and therefore of equal importance – so that the welfare of India was as reliant on having Afghanistan as a